

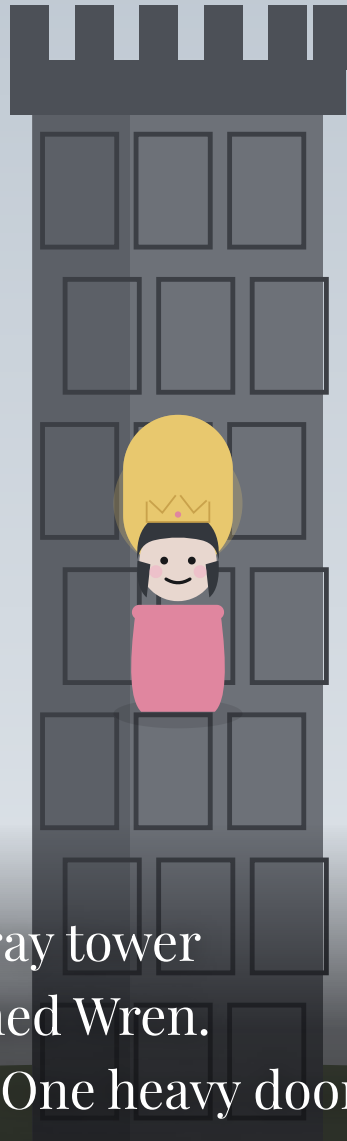


THE LITTLE REWRITES

# THE PRINCESS WHO RESCUED HERSELF

*A fairytale about writing your own happily ever after.*

MK PARRISH



At the top of a tall gray tower  
lived a princess named Wren.  
One round window. One heavy door.  
And one rule, for a princess:  
*wait.*



The kingdom told her story the same way every time.

One day, a prince will climb the tower.

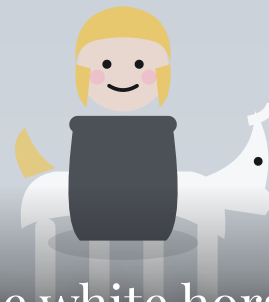
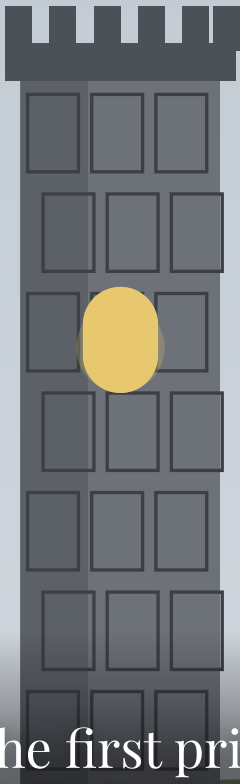
He will open the door.

He will set the princess free.

So Wren waited.

That, everyone agreed, was the whole point of her.





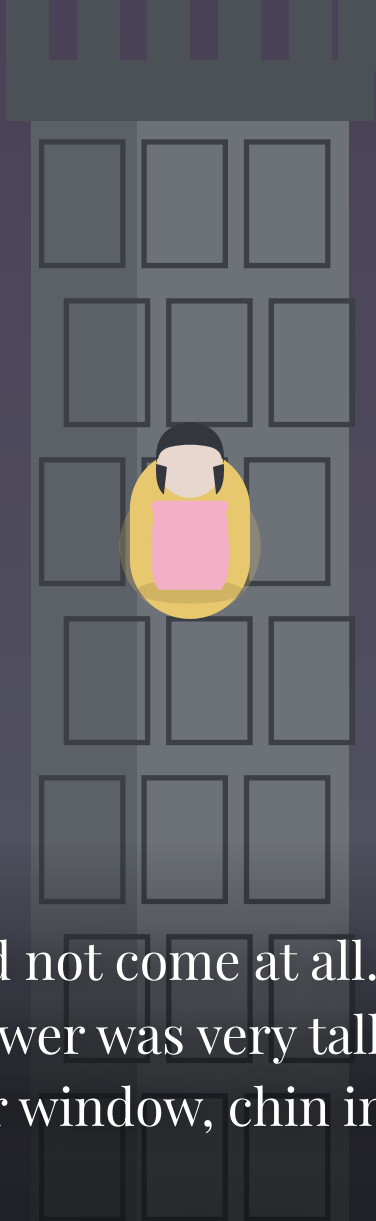
HMM.

The first prince rode up on a fine white horse.  
He looked at the heavy locked door.  
"This looks rather *difficult*," he said —  
and rode off to find an easier tower.



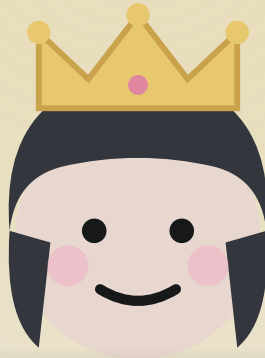
The second prince stood at the bottom and  
shouted,  
"Do not worry! I am here to rescue you!" **ZZZ...**  
Then he sat on a rock to rest from all that  
shouting,  
fell fast asleep,  
and by morning had forgotten which tower it  
was.





The third prince did not come at all.  
He had heard the tower was very tall.  
And Wren sat by her window, chin in her  
hands,  
while something in her that had been quiet a  
long, long time  
finally cleared its throat.

*why wait?*



*Why, thought Wren,  
am I waiting for someone  
who keeps not coming?*

It was a small thought.  
But small thoughts, in towers, echo.

She looked at the door properly this time —  
the way you look at something  
you have decided is *yours to solve*.  
The lock was on the outside.  
But the hinges —  
the hinges were on the *inside*.  
Nobody had ever mentioned the hinges.





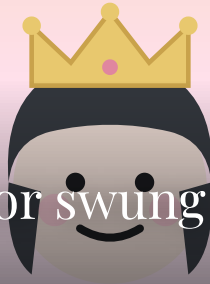
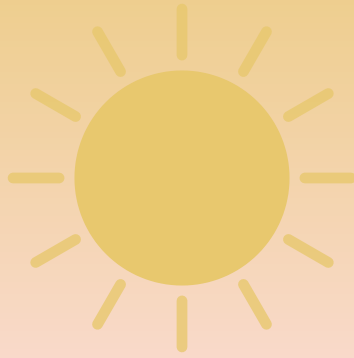
She had no sword.  
She had a hairpin, a candlestick,  
and a great deal of time  
she had meant to spend waiting.  
She worked, and rested, and worked again.  
And she found she did not mind the quiet.  
In the quiet, she could hear herself *think*.



GROAN...

By the time the moon was high,  
the bottom hinge came loose with a groan.  
By the time the birds woke,  
so did the top.  
Then Wren pushed —  
not at the silly lock (she left that just where it  
was),  
but at the *hinged* side.





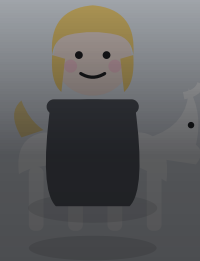
And the great heavy door swung the wrong way  
entirely —  
the way no door is ever supposed to swing —  
and fell open into the morning.  
The wind caught her hair.  
The whole green kingdom lay gold below.  
She had not been rescued.  
She had been *paying attention*.

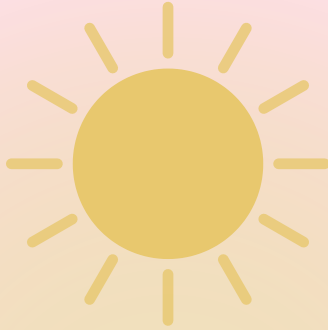
*but... who rescued you?*

On the road, she met the first prince,  
quite startled to see her walking about.  
"But — who *rescued* you?" he asked.

Wren thought about it.

Then she smiled,  
and told him the truest thing in this whole  
book.





"I did."

And she walked on into her own morning,  
in no particular hurry,  
because it was hers now. All of it.  
The road. The kingdom. The story —  
especially the story.  
She had picked up the pen  
and written herself a door.

FOR THE GROWN-UP READING ALONG

We give little girls a story early: something is wrong, and a prince will come and fix it. It is a lovely story and a terrible plan. This one keeps the tower and the prince and the happily-ever-after — and quietly hands the pen to the girl. When you finish, ask the small person listening the question the whole book is really about: *"What would you do, if the door was locked and nobody was coming?"* You may be surprised by how quickly they look for the hinges.